

SHESHAPESHISTORYEDIT

Travel Radio Australia, we're in Brisbane at the Arrival 360 travel event and I've run into Zoe Condleff and Zoe is a very interesting person. She runs a company called She Shapes History and it's female-based tours in Melbourne, Sydney and other places. Zoe, welcome to the program.

Thank you so much for having me, Geoffrey. Zoe, you were telling me that this is a fascinating tour that people can go on to celebrate the history of women in Melbourne and other cities. Tell us more about it.

Yeah, that's right. So we are She Shapes History. We run history tours but with a twist.

So we specifically focus on women's history and we run tours in Melbourne, Sydney, Canberra and Wollongong and we're expanding fast to other cities around the country as well. That's such a fascinating thing because especially in Melbourne and having lived in Melbourne for 25 years, it's got such a rich history. Can you tell us a couple of the stories of the women you highlight? Yeah, sure.

So we're actually based at the Queen Victoria Women's Centre in Melbourne and we start our tours there and one of my favourite stories, it's about Constance and Clara Stone who are the sisters who started the first ever women's hospital in Australia and Constance Stone, she had a goal and her goal was to be a doctor. She went to the University of Melbourne and they said, sorry, no, we don't allow women to study medicine. So she went overseas and she got two degrees in medicine and she came back and she said to the Victorian Medical Board, now can I be a doctor? And of course they said, nope, you still can't.

So she went overseas, she got two more degrees, she came back and finally she became the first female doctor in the country and her younger sister then meanwhile had been campaigning to let the University of Melbourne allow women in. So a year later she graduated as one of two of the first women to graduate. They noticed that there was a huge need for women who really needed and wanted a female doctor and so they started what became the Queen Victoria Women's Hospital, which almost was knocked down in the 80s and then a small group of women actually lobbied and campaigned to save that building, which is a gorgeous heritage building we now get to call home as She Shapes History and it's now a building completely dedicated to furthering the interests of Victorian women.

Such a great story and I suppose you have a bunch of these stories. Tell us about some of the guides you have doing these tours. Yeah, it's amazing.

Women's History is really good because we get to really dig and uncover stories that haven't been celebrated as much as they could and one of my favourite things, I used to also guide these tours, so one of my favourite things about guiding these tours is the element of surprise where

there are these absolutely remarkable jaw-dropping stories of women who have really overcome so many challenges and they might be women in the arts, women in sport, we actually have a limited edition tour specifically about women in sport at the moment in Melbourne and people just have never heard of them and you can see the shock on their faces that they can't believe they weren't taught about these women in school. So one of my favourite tours as well that we have going on, I think it's just an ongoing tour at this point in Canberra, is Spies in the Capital and it's about the history of espionage in Canberra and I think what's really cool about it is we get to talk about spies, who doesn't love talking about spies, but women were actually really significant players in that field. They make great spies because nobody suspects that a woman, a lovely and sometimes it's a lovely elderly woman or something like that, no one suspects she's going to be a spy, so we do lots of really fun tours like that as well which I love and we just have really dedicated ongoing guides, so we run a little bit differently because our guides are our employees and they love working for She Shapes History because they believe in the mission.

We actually believe that stories change the hearts and minds of people. It's the best when we're walking and talking through cities, it's one of the best ways to, I guess, change someone's opinion, you know, about women's contributions to society. Sure, Melbourne has such a rich history of art and culture and buildings.

Do you ever get into the little spooky area at all or anything like that? Yeah, well Melbourne does and we have one ongoing tour in Melbourne that is at the Abbotsford Convent and if you don't know what the Abbotsford Convent is, it is this gorgeous historic building right on the banks of the creek there in Melbourne, so it's actually a really nice calming tour, but then you get to go into the old laundries where the women were, you know, it's a little bit sad in some ways. They were actually often brought there against their will and they had to work in the laundries and many people believe that those laundries are haunted. They are absolutely incredible.

Sometimes we even get behind-the-scenes access which you can't get as a member of the public to go into those laundries and go into that old convent and see, peek into what the lives of those women were like who lived and worked there during that time. And what's a couple of your favourite examples of these tours? What really stands out for you? Yeah, I mean I think we're a niche tour company but we sell out tickets all the time so I think that that's just because people want to walk with us and see their city with a different lens. So we're able to take people kind of on this journey for two hours and celebrate this entire part of history that we don't often hear about and that we should hear about and know about and I think overall that's my favourite thing.

And I think we tell stories like, for example, the story of Adela Pankhurst who, if you know about the suffragettes in the UK, you probably know the Pankhurst but a lot of people don't know about their lost Australian daughter, Adela Pankhurst. So we tell stories like that where these women have lived really interesting and also very unexpected lives because a lot of the time the women we talk about, they've had to be difficult and they've had to break the rules and so it's fun in that

way that we get to kind of tell these stories about these women who've just been really, really bold and fought against systems that were designed to keep them quiet. It's so fascinating and people can join you, I mean they can find you online, She Shapes History, Zoe Condliffe.

And how did it start? Did you just have this germ of an idea and it all just sprung into life? How did it happen? Yeah, so our tour started in Canberra. Our founder, Sita Sargent, started them and she was just running the tours in Canberra herself each weekend. That went on for a little while until she realised it was a really, really great idea.

People love the tours and in the last 12 months we've expanded really quickly to Melbourne and Sydney and Wollongong as well. I get to have the fun job of researching and creating all of the tours. So we're now just looking forward to the next chapter where we're going to be launching in Brisbane, Perth, Hobart and Adelaide next year.

So stay tuned and watch out. I suppose you're looking for guides too? We will be. We're looking for guides.

Working with the guides is one of my favourite parts of running the tour company. I think, you know, it's really, really nice because we're still relatively small. We have really good kind of close relationships with those guides so it's a lot of fun.

I still sometimes, I'm running a tour this Saturday myself, you know. I love still being able to kind of dip my toe in and do it on the ground. Well Zoe, how can people find out more online about She Shapes History? Yeah, well we have a really good newsletter.

Every week we share stories of these women. You can jump on our website, subscribe to our newsletter and our Instagram's the big one. I think everyone loves our Instagram at She Shapes History.

Fantastic. Thank you very much for joining us on the program. Yeah, we hope to see you on a tour soon.

We'd love to. Thank you. Bye.